Organized Loneliness in the 21st Century

Diane Enns: Organized Loneliness

Standard Responses to Loneliness

- **Loneliness is rarely a central topic in philosophy**, unlike solitude, which philosophers often praise as necessary and pleasurable for thinking.
- **Loneliness differs from solitude**: it is a painful feeling of isolation that can occur even when one is not physically alone.
- **Hannah Arendt and Franco "Bifo" Berardi are key exceptions** who treat loneliness as a serious philosophical and political issue.

Arendt's concept of "organized loneliness" (in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*)

- Loneliness can be systemically produced, not just personally experienced.
- Totalitarian regimes deliberately cultivate isolation.
- Loneliness is more dangerous than mere political powerlessness.
- As a "tool of terror," it can "ravage the world" by destroying shared human bonds.

Berardi updates Arendt's concerns for the present day

- Today's loneliness stems from "high-tech capitalism," not totalitarianism.
- It is produced by interconnected forces:
  - Precarious, competitive work environments
  - Financial abstraction
  - Digital communication systems
  - Breakdown of social structures that provide care and community
- Loneliness appears alongside anxiety, depression, alienation, and loss of empathy.
- These symptoms signal a deep social crisis or "anthropological mutation."

Critique of popular “loneliness crisis” narratives:

- Media often frame loneliness as a public health epidemic.
- Solutions tend to individualize the problem, blaming the lonely person.
- Explanations (e.g.,blaming social media) oversimplify complex structural causes.

Loneliness has both existential and structural dimensions

- It may be a basic human experience.
- But it is also shaped by political, economic, and social conditions.
- Social, political, and psychological factors interact in producing it.

Core insight from Arendt and Berardi

- Humans have a deep need for one another across many forms of togetherness—political solidarity, community, and intimate love.
- The erosion of these forms of connection threatens the shared world we depend on.
- If these breakdowns continue, mass loneliness could indeed “ravage the world,” as Arendt feared.

The Totalitarian Organization of Loneliness

Context

- Arendt develops the idea of "organized loneliness" in the final chapter of *The Origins of Totalitarianism*, distinguishing totalitarianism from other forms of tyranny.
  - Totalitarianism combines **terror + the rigid logic of ideology**.
  - She seeks to identify the **basic human experiences** that make totalitarian domination possible.

Isolation vs. Loneliness (key distinction)

- **Isolation (political realm):**
  - Prevents solidarity and collective action.
  - Makes politics—defined as speaking and acting together—impossible.
  - Is fertile ground for terror and often its result.
  - Tyrants cultivate isolation through fear and suspicion (neighbor against neighbor).
  - However, isolation does *not* eliminate private friendship or intimacy.
  - Can be productive (e.g., artistic creation, philosophical thinking).
  - This productive aloneness resembles **solitude**.

Loneliness (Social and Existential realm)

- A deeper condition: feeling deserted by all human companionship.
- Involves losing not only others, but also one's sense of self and belonging in the world.
- One feels uprooted, superfluous, and unable to rely on shared reality.
- It affects "human life as a whole," not just political life.

The “two-in-one” and the loss of self

- In thinking, we engage in an inner dialogue (the “two-in-one”).
- Even when alone, we remain connected to others through this inner dialogue.
- Loneliness destroys this internal companionship.
- Without others to affirm us, the self collapses.
- Thus loneliness means losing:
  - Others
  - The relational self
  - The shared world
  - The capacity for meaningful thought and experience

Loneliness as unbearable and contradictory to human plurality

- Human beings are plural by nature.
- Loneliness contradicts this condition and is therefore intolerable long-term.
- Arendt warns against adapting to loneliness as if it were normal.

Logical ideology vs. thinking

- The only mental process that does not require self, others, or world is **pure logical reasoning**.
- Totalitarianism relies on the “inherent logicality” of ideology.
- Endless logical calculation replaces freedom, spontaneity, and genuine thought.
- (Berardi later adds: logicality leaves no room for empathy.)

The Political Function of Loneliness

- The lonely person's suffering reflects a broader social failure.
- Loneliness is individually experienced but structurally produced.
- Its political usefulness (for domination) is hidden by its psychological appearance.

The “iron band of terror”

- Terror presses individuals together so tightly that movement and action cease.
- It eliminates the space between people necessary for political life.
- Paradoxically, it also destroys real human togetherness by reducing people to a mass.
- This undermines shared “common sense” and trust in shared reality.

Loneliness as preparation for totalitarian domination

- Replaces thinking with ideological logic.
- Destroys shared sensory experience of the world.
- Becomes normalized as an everyday mass experience.
- Blurs boundaries between political, social, and psychological life.

Arendt's Warning

- Totalitarian organization of loneliness creates a "desert world" where nothing and no one is reliable.
- The greatest danger is not suffering in desert conditions, but becoming at home in them—accepting loneliness as normal.

The Iron Band of Technology

Berardi's "desertification" of the human landscape

- Contemporary society is undergoing a sweeping transformation due to digitalized capitalism.
- This "anthropological mutation" shifts us from an "alphabetical" culture to a digital infosphere.
- The result is a ravaging or "desertification" of social life.

From “conjunction” to “connection”: a key shift in human relations

Conjunction (empathetic, creative relation):

- Based on empathy and emotional understanding.
- We become “other to ourselves,” entering into another’s experience.
- Exchanges are meaningful and creative, producing something new.
- Sensitive to nuance, context, intention, and what is left unsaid.
- Fully embodied: involves emotion, sensibility, and presence.

Connection (functional, logical relation)

- Based on compliance with rules and syntactic structures.
- Functional, repeatable, algorithmic exchanges.
- No real empathy, nuance, or ambiguity.
- Nothing new is created; interaction is useful but not meaningful.
- Governed by "the logic of connection," serving efficiency in high-tech capitalism.

Echoes of Arendt

- Logical processes replace genuine thinking and freedom.
- Shared sensual experience and embodied presence decline.
- Technology becomes a contemporary parallel to ideological logic.

Digital Communication and Everyday Life

- Face-to-face nuance replaced by emojis, likes, swipes, caps.
- Easier to ignore others (digital silence).
- Connective logic spills into in-person interactions (rage, dismissal, discourtesy).
- Erosion of empathy and affect weakens our ability to understand others' complexity.

The “iron band of technology”

- A modern analogue to Arendt’s “iron band of terror.”
- Instead of fear, pleasure and convenience draw us into submission.
- We willingly trade privacy and individuality for recognition and ease.
- Pressed together digitally, yet pulled apart bodily and socially.
- Solidarity, community, and friendship lose meaning.

Identity and Belonging

- Longing to belong persists, but meaningful communities weaken.
- This can produce nostalgia for identities that never truly existed.
- Such nostalgia may fuel identity-based violence.

Technology + capitalism (not technology alone)

- Digital mutation occurs within “capitalist absolutism.”
- Effects visible in environmental crisis, weakened welfare systems, education decline, economic precarity.
- Intensified competition and work rhythms erode solidarity.
- Social movements struggle in a fragmented, competitive environment.

Financial abstraction and automation

- Power becomes impersonal and algorithmic.
- “Faceless operativity of automatisms” replaces identifiable decision-makers.
- Capital grows autonomously, beyond individual control.

A “factory of unhappiness”

- Rising loneliness, anxiety, depression, suicide.
- These are attempts to adapt to or escape desert conditions.

Loneliness and contemporary terror

- Unlike totalitarian mass terror, today's terror may appear as the isolated mass shooter.
- The lonely, uprooted individual becomes the agent of violence.
- Loneliness remains a "tool of terror," but now dispersed and individualized rather than state-organized.

At Home in the Desert

Arendt's fear revisited

- We may adapt to "desert" conditions—accepting the loss of plurality, meaningful action, and creative thought.
- Berardi adds: we may adjust to a disembodied, empathy-poor life where even the "soul is put to work."
- Our adaptations to organized loneliness are deeply **ambivalent**.

Work as a central site of organized loneliness

- Modern work is flexible, precarious, competitive, and largely cognitive ("cognitarians").
- Work is portable and constant; it follows us everywhere via digital technology.
- Convenience and flexibility come at the cost of shared workplaces and daily embodied interaction.
- Loss of informal social rituals (coffee chats, shared offices) weakens belonging.

Material isolation → psychic isolation

- Remote and digital work reduce shared physical spaces.
- Academic and professional environments foster silos through competition.
- Even communal spaces (cafés, lunch breaks) are absorbed into work.
- Students show signs of social and intellectual withdrawal:
  - Reluctance to form discussion groups
  - Fear of disagreement
  - Conformity that suppresses independent thinking
- Competitive pressure fuels anxiety and psychological breakdown.

Work-Loneliness Cycle

- The more we work, the less time we spend with others.
- The lonelier we are, the more we turn to work for structure and meaning.
- Work becomes life; to-do lists replace shared experiences.

Family and coupledom as “lifeboats”

- As broader social life erodes, we rely heavily on intimate partners and family.
- Families become default units for care, support, and recognition.
- This intensifies pressure on couple relationships.
- The family can be “anti-social,” making the outside world feel cold.
- Its desirability masks its role in sustaining organized loneliness.

Shifting Family Structures

- Declines in marriage and childbirth; rise in solo living.
- Some elderly die alone, unnoticed for long periods (e.g., tens of thousands of such deaths annually in Japan).
- Weakening family obligations expose vulnerabilities.

Hikikomori (extreme withdrawal)

- Mostly men in Japan withdraw completely from work and society.
- Seen not just as pathology, but as adaptation to unbearable competition and precarity.
- A "fully understandable withdrawal from hell."
- Represents a stark form of adjustment to organized loneliness.

Loneliness as foundational to high-tech capitalism

- Comparable to loneliness under totalitarianism (Arendt).
- But unlike terror regimes, today's "iron band of technology" involves **choice**.
- We choose efficiency, convenience, independence—and accept loneliness as the cost.

Freedom and Loneliness

- Modern freedom includes not being bothered by others.
- But this freedom brings impoverished shared sensibility and social bonds.
- Loneliness becomes the price of convenience.

Resistance through Inconvenience

- To resist organized loneliness, we must accept being interrupted or inconvenienced.
- Solidarity, friendship, courtesy, and care become acts of resistance.
- Human togetherness is the clear antithesis of loneliness—
- Yet when loneliness becomes normalized, we may forget that such an alternative exists.